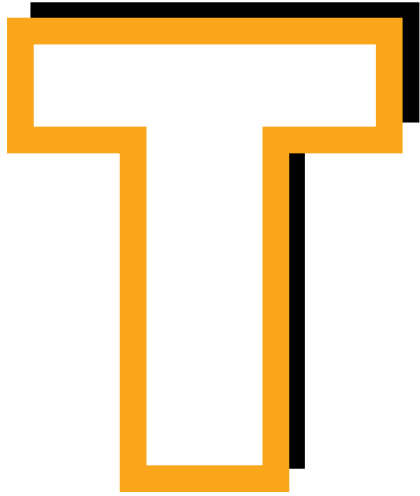




38 | THE TIPPING POINT. Yes, we know it is a book by Malcolm Gladwell. But we don't know if Mahendra Singh Dhoni has read it. What we do know is that this legendary wicketkeeper-batsman marshalled a relatively young and inexperienced team that ultimately led to the tipping point for Indian cricket's burst into the modern era and dominance since. On a warm afternoon on September 24, 2007, Pakistan were within touching distance of victory in the final of the inaugural Twenty-20 (T20) World Cup in the historic South African city of Johannesburg. Star Pakistani batsman Misbah-ul-Haq had hit the second ball of the final over for a six. With just six more runs needed for victory, the batter wanted to finish off proceedings with a flourish. Misbah went for the scoop shot over short fine-leg, but only skied the ball—and was caught. Pakistan were all out and India—led by first-time captain Dhoni—were champions! The victory saw India erupt into unbridled celebration, with a frenzy not seen since the country's first ICC tournament victory, the legendary ODI (one-day international) World Cup win at the hallowed Lord's ground in England in 1983. Then, too, a bunch of no-hopers had gone on to lift the then greatest trophy in the sport.

The 2007 win and the subsequent hysteria birthed a new idea in the brains of Indian cricket's administrators and money managers—T20 cricket could be milked for far more money than the sport had ever seen before. And thus, it was that on April

18, 2008, was born the Indian Premier League or IPL, with the first match between Kolkata Knight Riders and Royal Challengers Bangalore seeing the former pulverise its opponent courtesy a knock for the ages by Kiwi wicketkeeper Brendon McCullum. That explosive knock by McCullum (158 in 73 balls, 13 sixes) was emblematic of the journey that the IPL would take, not just for Indian cricket as a sport, but also for Indian cricket as a multi-billion-dollar industry. “The rest of the world was saying the IPL was much bigger than what Kerry Packer had done in the 1970s,” says celebrated cricket commentator Harsha Bhogle. “We had players prioritising the IPL over everything else since there was big money to be made.”

Today, the IPL, spread over eight weeks, with 10 teams comprising a total of 163 players, many of who are from other countries, and played across 12 cities, is a spectacular, fast-moving caravan of sheer entertainment, sporting conflict, heroes, villains, and humongous crowds of men, women and children in the stadiums—and multiples of that at homes and screening centres across the country—screaming themselves hoarse with every six and four, and equally, screaming in agony with each dropped catch and each wicket.



Its [IPL's] capacity to aggregate viewers at such scale in a short burst of time combined with the intense engagement it delivers renders it unique”

SANJOG GUPTA

Head-Sports,
Disney Star

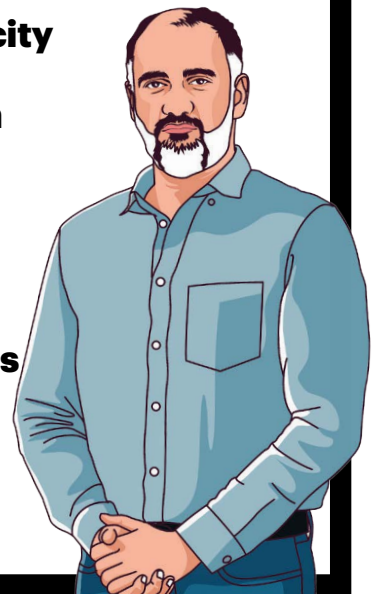


ILLUSTRATION BY RAJ VERMA